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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

English

Verbal Ability

Official Syllabus · Language Test · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Aligned to the latest official syllabus · Concept-first explanations

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA official CUET(UG) 2026 syllabus — English (101), the current 2027 baseline)	Skills the questions test
Rearranging the parts	Rearranging the parts	Rebuilding a scrambled paragraph — spotting openers, pronoun links and connectors.
Match the following	Match the following	Pairing items across two columns and verifying every pair before marking.
Choosing the correct word	Choosing the correct word	Fitting the right word into a blank by sense, grammar and usual partners.
Synonyms and antonyms	Synonyms and Antonyms	Judging word meaning in context — the closest match and the true opposite.

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EXAM PATTERN

CUET UG pattern (NTA official information bulletin and syllabus, 2026 cycle — the current 2027 baseline): each test paper carries **50 compulsory questions** in **60 minutes**, with +5 for every correct answer and −1 for every incorrect answer. The English syllabus names four verbal-ability families — rearranging the parts, match the following, choosing the correct word, synonyms and antonyms — all of them speed skills: each question rewards a fixed method over a long think.

What Verbal Ability Rewards

Vocabulary questions look like memory tests. They are not — not entirely. What actually decides your score is a **small set of methods** applied with discipline: find the opener in a jumble, anchor the pairs you know in a match, run three checks on every blank, and predict your own word before reading the options for a synonym. A student with a decent-but-not-giant vocabulary and sharp methods beats a word-hoard with no method, every single time.

- **Four families, four fixed methods.** Rearranging parts, match the following, choosing the correct word, synonyms and antonyms — each has a routine you can rehearse.

- **Speed comes from method, not rushing.** A 30-second method beats a 3-minute stare. Practise the routine until it runs itself.
- **Context is the referee.** Every word question lives inside a sentence; the sentence, not the dictionary, picks the winner.
- **Your ears will lie to you.** Sound-alike pairs (advice/advise) and pleasant-sounding options exist to catch by-ear answering. Checks, not vibes.
- **Word power still matters** — but it grows daily in small doses (a roots table and a word diary, both in this PDF), not overnight.

REAL-WORLD ANALOGY

Verbal ability is like **sorting a box of mixed Lego bricks**. The jumble is the picture on the box lid — you find the corner pieces first (the opener), then click obvious neighbours together. Matching is pairing left bricks with right bricks — the sure pairs click first. Blanks are a missing brick — the shape around it (sense + grammar) announces which piece fits. No guessing needed; the bricks declare their places.

Rearranging the Parts: The Jumble Method

A scrambled paragraph is a small mystery, and the clues are grammar words. Sentences in English hang together with **pronouns** (he, she, it, this, these, they) that point BACKWARD to something already mentioned, and **connectors** (but, then, so, finally, however) that announce the order. Read the four sentences once, mark every pronoun and connector, and the paragraph almost assembles itself.

- **Step 1 — Hunt the opener.** The opening sentence introduces a person, place or idea by NAME. It has no dangling "he/it/they" pointing at nothing.
- **Step 2 — Follow the pronouns.** "Meena planted a seed. **It** sprouted within weeks." — "It" must follow the sentence that names the seed.
- **Step 3 — Respect the connectors.** "But" signals a twist after a setup; "Finally" closes a list; "By midnight" pushes time forward.
- **Step 4 — Snap the pairs.** Two sentences that share a noun-pronoun chain stick together as one block.
- **Step 5 — Read the full order once.** It should sound like one smooth paragraph. If any joint creaks, swap and re-check.

SOLVED JUMBLE — THE CAMPING STORM

P. The sky had been grey since morning, and a drizzle began while we set up the tent. Q. By midnight the storm had bent the poles and soaked our sleeping bags. R. We finally hiked to the forest rest house, laughing at our luck. S. Nobody expected what the sky did next.

- **Opener hunt:** P introduces the scene (sky, tent) with no dangling pronoun — S talks about "what the sky did next", which needs the drizzle established first. Start with P.
- **Connector logic:** S builds suspense → Q delivers the storm "by midnight" (time moves forward) → R closes with "finally".

- **Correct order: P → S → Q → R.** Read it once — smooth from drizzle to storm to rescue.

Match the Following: Pair, Strike, Verify

Two columns, four pairs, one mark — but also four chances to slip, because one wrong pair sinks the whole answer. The method that protects you is **anchoring**: lock the pairs you are certain about first, strike them out, and match the leftovers from a much shorter list. Confidence first, doubt later.

- **Step 1 — Scan for sure pairs.** If you know "flock — birds" instantly, lock it and mentally strike both items.
- **Step 2 — Narrow the field.** After two strikes, each remaining column has only two candidates — a 50/50 becomes two 50/50s handled separately, not one confusing fog of eight items.
- **Step 3 — Never trust a single pair.** Check all four before marking; options are built so that a partially correct match appears as a full option.
- **Step 4 — Watch the reuse trick.** Options may reuse a column-I item in two different mappings ("1-c" and "1-d") — your locked pairs decide instantly.

SOLVED MATCH — COLLECTIVE NOUNS

Match the group names with the animals: (1) flock · (2) school · (3) pride · (4) swarm — against (a) bees (b) fish (c) birds (d) lions.

- **Sure pairs first:** flock—birds (c) and pride—lions (d) — lock both, strike them out.
- **Leftovers:** school and swarm remain against bees and fish. "A school of fish" is the classic phrase — school—fish (a) — leaving swarm—bees (b).
- **Full check:** 1-c, 2-a, 3-d, 4-b — all four verified, then mark.

Choosing the Correct Word: The Three Checks

A blank is a shape, and the words around it are the mould. Every fill-in-the-blank question answers to three quick checks, always in the same order: **sense** (does the meaning fit?), **grammar** (is it the right part of speech?), and **partners** (does this word usually travel with these neighbours?). Words that sound alike but never swap roles — the confusables — are the most recycled traps in this family, and the table below is your permanent defence.

Confusable pair	Word 1 — role and example	Word 2 — role and example
affect / effect	**affect** — verb, to change: "The rain affected the match"	**effect** — noun, the result: "The effect was immediate"
advice / advise	**advice** — noun, what you give: "Her advice helped"	**advise** — verb, the act: "She advised patience"

Confusable pair	Word 1 — role and example	Word 2 — role and example
principal / principle	**principal** — chief or head: "the principal reason"	**principle** — a rule you believe: "a matter of principle"
stationary / stationery	**stationary** — not moving: "a stationary bus"	**stationery** — paper and pens: "a stationery shop"
lose / loose	**lose** — misplace: "lose your keys"	**loose** — not tight: "a loose button"
compliment / complement	**compliment** — praise: "a kind compliment"	**complement** — completes: "the scarf complements the dress"
its / it's	**its** — belonging to it: "its cover"	**it's** — short for "it is": "it's late"
than / then	**than** — comparison: "taller than me"	**then** — time: "and then we left"

SOLVED BLANKS — ONE PAIR, TWO CHECKS

"The medicine had an immediate _____ on the fever, but it did not _____ the infection."

- **First blank:** "an immediate _____" needs a NOUN after an article — **effect** (the result). Sense check: "immediate effect on the fever" — natural partners.
- **Second blank:** "did not _____" needs a VERB — **affect** (to change). Sense check: "did not affect the infection" — fits.
- **Answer: effect, affect.** Grammar decided the shape, sense confirmed the fit — the pair never swaps.

Synonyms and Antonyms: Predict, Then Match

Here lives the most famous trap in verbal ability: in an antonym question, a **perfect synonym** waits inside the options, dressed attractively. The defence is a fixed ritual. Read the sentence with the word in it. Say your OWN replacement word aloud — before you look at the options. If the question asks for a synonym, match your prediction. If it asks for an antonym, **flip** your prediction first, then match. The sentence decides which meaning of the word is even alive: "run" in "a run of good luck" has nothing to do with jogging.

- **Step 1 — Read the sentence, not just the word.** Which meaning of the word is the sentence using?
- **Step 2 — Predict your own word.** Cover the options; say a replacement aloud.
- **Step 3 — Synonym: match the prediction.** Antonym: flip the prediction FIRST — "abundant" → plentiful → opposite: **scarce**.
- **Step 4 — Use word charge.** Tag words + or −: hostile is −, candid is +. Antonyms flip the charge; synonyms keep it.
- **Step 5 — Re-read with your choice inside.** The sentence's meaning must survive untouched.

Word	Closest meaning (synonym)	True opposite (antonym)	One-line sense
candid	frank, honest	secretive, guarded	says the truth plainly, even when awkward
valiant	brave, courageous	cowardly, timid	faces danger despite fear
abundant	plentiful, ample	scarce, sparse	more than enough of something
hostile	unfriendly, aggressive	welcoming, cordial	acting like an enemy
cautious	careful, wary	reckless, rash	moves only after checking

Building Word Power That Sticks

You cannot memorise a dictionary in a term — and you do not need to. Two small habits, run daily, quietly multiply your vocabulary: **word roots** (one root unlocks a family of words) and a **word diary** (one word a day, used in your own sentence). Five minutes a day for a month beats a five-hour cram the night before — vocabulary settles with repetition, the same way music practice does.

Root	Meaning	Words it unlocks
bene-	good, well	benefit, benevolent (kind), beneficial, benefactor (helper)
mal-	bad, wrong	malice, malfunction, malnutrition, malevolent (wishing harm)
chron-	time	chronology, chronicle, chronic (lasting long), synchronise
spect-	look, see	inspect, spectator, spectacle, perspective, respect (look back at)
port-	carry	transport, portable, export, import, porter (one who carries)
bio-	life	biology, biography, antibiotic, biodiversity

- **The word-diary ritual:** one new word a day — write its meaning in five words of your own, one sentence about YOUR life, and one partner word it often travels with.
- **Charge-tag every new word:** + or −. A week of tags later, synonym and antonym questions start answering themselves.
- **Revise the diary weekly**, ten words at a time — old words are worth more than new ones.

Key Rules and Strategies: One-Stop Revision

VERBAL ABILITY — EVERY METHOD ON ONE PAGE

Rule	Statement	Exam use
Opener rule	First sentence introduces by name; no dangling he/it/they	Jumble first sentence
Pronoun compass	Pronouns point backward to a named thing	Jumble ordering
Connector clock	But = twist, then = time, finally = close	Jumble ordering
Snap pairs	Noun-pronoun chains form blocks that move together	Longer jumbles
Anchor pairs	Lock sure matches first, strike, then match leftovers	Match the following
Verify all four	One wrong pair sinks the whole option	Match the following
Three checks	Sense, grammar, usual partners — in that order	Every blank
Confusables	affect/effect, advice/advise, its/it's, lose/loose — fixed roles	Blank and error questions
Predict first	Say your own word before reading options	Synonyms, blanks
Antonym flip	Flip your prediction before matching	Antonym questions
Charge tags	Positive/negative labels settle synonym-antonym fast	Word questions
Roots	bene-, mal-, chron-, spect-, port-, bio- unlock word families	Unseen words

Common Errors and Special Cases

THE TRAPS THIS TOPIC SETS — READ BEFORE THE MOCK

The habit you assume	The twist	The trap in the question
"The first option that sounds nice"	By-ear answering is exactly what traps test	All four families
"Jumbles start anywhere"	A pronoun sentence cannot open — it points backward	Rearranging the parts
"Two matches right = done"	All four pairs must verify before marking	Match the following
"Affect and effect swap freely"	affect = verb (to change), effect = noun (result)	Choosing the correct word
"Synonym questions and antonym questions feel the same"	The synonym sits in antonym options as bait	Synonyms and antonyms
"Hard words need grand replacements"	Context wants the plain, fitting word	Vocabulary in context
"A big vocabulary is built in one night"	Roots and a daily diary do the real work	Preparation planning
"Every word has one fixed meaning"	Run, kind, mean — the sentence picks the meaning	All word questions

The 60-Second Self-Test

Cover the answers, say each one aloud, then check. If any answer takes longer than ten seconds, revisit that section.

- **What kind of sentence can never open a jumble?** → One starting with a dangling pronoun (He / It / They…).
- **Name the three checks for every blank, in order.** → Sense, grammar, usual partners.
- **In "match the following", what do you lock FIRST?** → The pairs you are sure of — then strike and narrow.
- **What is the first move in an antonym question?** → Predict your word, then FLIP it before matching.
- **affect or effect: "The medicine had an immediate _____"?** → effect — a noun after an article.
- **What does the root chron- mean, and name two of its words?** → Time — chronology, chronic, synchronise.

The Whole Chapter in One Picture

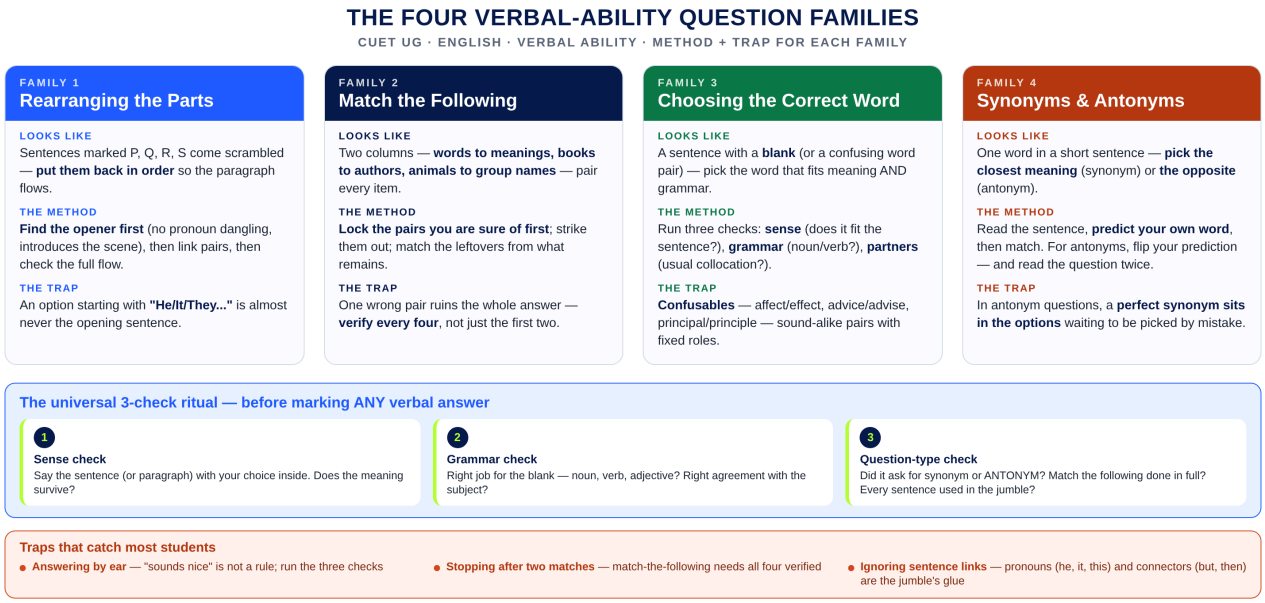


Figure 1: The four verbal-ability families side by side — what each looks like, the fixed method for each, and the trap hiding inside — with the universal three-check ritual below.

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Figure 2: Chapter mindmap: the four families, the word-power habits, the scoring rituals, and the traps that catch most students.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions in the CUET UG style — two per family pattern, exactly the mix you just revised. Each correct answer earns +5; each incorrect one costs −1, so run the checks before marking.

Q1. P: It slowly filled the whole sky, blocking the afternoon sun. · Q: A strange grey cloud appeared over the fields just after lunch. · R: Soon the rain arrived, washing the dusty roads. · S: By evening, the village had never looked so clean and cool.

The correct order is:

(A) Q R P S
(B) P Q R S
(C) Q P R S
(D) P R Q S

Q2. P: Her first loaf came out hard as a brick. · Q: Still, she kept baking every Sunday that year. · R: Today her bread wins prizes at the district fair. · S: Grandmother learned to bake from a library book.

The correct order is:

(A) S P Q R
(B) P S Q R
(C) S Q P R
(D) P Q S R

Q3. Match the words with their meanings: (1) candid (2) furious (3) ancient (4) vacant — with (a) very angry (b) very old (c) empty (d) completely honest:

(A) 1-d, 2-a, 3-b, 4-c
(B) 1-a, 2-d, 3-c, 4-b
(C) 1-c, 2-b, 3-d, 4-a
(D) 1-d, 2-b, 3-a, 4-c

Q4. The new coach's training had an immediate _____ on the team's fitness. Choose the correct word:

(A) affect
(B) effect
(C) affective
(D) effectively

Q5. The lawyer gave sound _____ before the hearing began. Choose the correct word:

(A) advise
(B) advices
(C) advice
(D) advising

Q6. Please keep the trolley _____ while the train is moving — it should not roll. Choose the correct word:

(A) stationery
(B) stationary
(C) stationaire
(D) stationer

Q7. The garden was abundant with mangoes this summer. The word "abundant" most nearly means:

(A) empty
(B) plentiful
(C) expensive
(D) famous

Q8. The valiant firefighter carried two children out of the smoke. The word "valiant" most nearly means:

(A) careless
(B) wealthy
(C) brave
(D) exhausted

Q9. Choose the word MOST NEARLY OPPOSITE to "hostile":

(A) angry
(B) unfriendly
(C) cordial
(D) aggressive

Q10. Choose the word MOST NEARLY OPPOSITE to "transparent":

(A) clear
(B) opaque
(C) fragile
(D) colourful

Detailed Solutions

Each solution shows the working, not just the verdict — cover the answer line, attempt the reasoning, then compare.

Sol. Q1. Opener: Q names the scene (a grey cloud, after lunch) — P opens with "It", which needs the cloud named first. Chain: P's "It" = the cloud → R's "soon the rain arrived" → S's "by evening" closes the day. Order Q-P-R-S.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q2. Opener: S introduces Grandmother and the library book. P's "Her first loaf" needs her named; Q's "Still" twists after the failure; R's "Today" closes years later. Order S-P-Q-R.

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q3. Anchor pairs: candid—honest (1-d) and furious—angry (2-a) lock first. Leftovers: ancient—old (3-b), vacant—empty (4-c). All four verified: 1-d, 2-a, 3-b, 4-c.

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q4. After an article ("an immediate _____") the blank needs a NOUN — effect. Affect is the verb; the other two options are the wrong word family entirely.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q5. "Gave sound _____" needs a NOUN (the thing given) — advice. Advise is the verb ("she advised"), and "advices" is not an English plural.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q6. Not moving = stationary. Stationery means paper and pens — the classic shop-sign mix-up; options C and D are not real English words in this sense.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q7. Predict before looking: "abundant with mangoes" — something like full or overflowing. Plentiful matches; empty flips the sense; expensive and famous drift off it.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. Carrying children out of smoke is a brave act, and "valiant" carries that + charge. Careless and exhausted are neutral-to-negative; wealthy is off the sense entirely.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q9. Predict, then FLIP: hostile = unfriendly (negative) → opposite = friendly and warm. Cordial means warmly friendly — the flip. The other three are all synonyms or near-synonyms of hostile.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q10. Predict, then FLIP: transparent = clear, see-through → opposite = blocks sight. Opaque is exactly that. Option A is the synonym bait — the classic antonym trap this chapter warned about.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

Dropped marks above? Find your slip here and rewrite the corrected rule in your own words.

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q1 option B	Opening with a pronoun sentence	"It" needs a named thing behind it — open with Q, the namer
Q3 option B or D	Marking after two matches	Verify all four pairs — leftovers settle once anchors are struck
Q4 option A	Swapping the affect/effect roles	affect = verb (to change); effect = the noun result
Q7 option A	Reading abundant as its opposite	Abundant = plentiful (positive charge); empty flips the charge
Q9 option B	Choosing a synonym for an antonym	Flip first: hostile is negative, so hunt the warm word — cordial
Q10 option A	Falling for the synonym bait	In antonym questions the near-synonym is always waiting — skip it

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